Operators, subscripts, literals, `callAsFunction`, `~=`

swift · folio

In one line: Operators are ordinary (usually `static`) functions with special syntax; a **precedence group** decides how an unparenthesised expression *parses*. Subscripts are property-like members called with `[ ]`. A literal has no type until context picks an `ExpressibleBy…Literal` type. `~=` is what `switch` calls per pattern.

Stdlib precedence, high → low (a partial order)

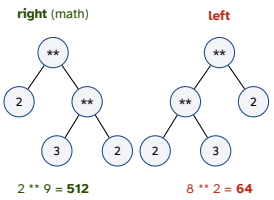
BitwiseShift	`<< >>`	*none*
Multiplication	`* / % &`	*left*
Addition	`+ - \| ^`	*left*
RangeFormation	`..< ...`	*none*
Casting	`is as as? as!`	*none*
NilCoalescing	`??`	*right*
Comparison	`== < === ~=`	*none*
LogicalConjunction	`&&`	*left*
LogicalDisjunction	`\|\|`	*left*
Ternary	`? :`	*right*
Assignment	`= +=`	*right, assignment*

higherThan — `Power (custom)`: above `*` and all below it; vs `<<` **unordered** → `a<<b**c` won't compile

C differs: & binds like `*`, | like +; `a<b<c` is an error (none)

higherThan — `Default`: a group-less operator: above `?:` only — `a+++b+c` = "unordered precedence groups"

`2**3**2` — associativity decides



none (the default): compile error

`switch v { case p: }` runs `p ~= v`: pattern **left**, value right, returns `Bool`

How it works

- **Declare, then implement**: `infix operator **:` `PowerPrecedence` at file scope; implement as `static func` in a type (found by overload resolution via the operand types) or a global `func`. `prefix`/`postfix` funcs carry the modifier; infix ones don't.
- **Whitespace decides fixity**: space on both sides or neither = infix; `-x` prefix; `x!` postfix. `a -b` is *not* subtraction.
- **Reserved**: `=`, `->`, `.`, `?:`, `//`, `/*`, prefix `&`, postfix `? !`. `&&`/`||` *are* overloadable — their right side is an `@autoclosure`, which is how they short-circuit.
- **`precedencegroup`**: `higherThan`/`lowerThan`, `associativity` (`left`/`right`/none, default none), `assignment: true` (folds into optional chains like `=`).
- **Subscripts**: parameters have **no argument labels** unless you name one (`subscript(row r: Int)` → `g[row: 1]`); several params, variadic, defaults, **generic** (4.0), **`static`** (5.1, `Color["brand"]`), get-only may be `async throws` (5.5). No set-only subscripts.
- **Literals**: the compiler calls the literal init of the *contextual* type, else the default (`Int`, `Double`, `String`, `Array`…).
- **`callAsFunction`** (5.2, SE-0253): makes `value(args)` work; overloads, labels, `mutating`, `async` allowed. SwiftUI's `dismiss()` is a `DismissAction` value. `@dynamicCallable` = the untyped, variadic cousin (scripting interop).
- **`~=`**: stdlib has it for `Equatable` (`==`) and `RangeExpression` (`contains`); overload it to use a type as a `case` pattern.

Protocol (`ExpressibleBy…`)	**required init**
`IntegerLiteral` · `FloatLiteral`	`init(integerLiteral:)` · `(floatLiteral:)`
`BooleanLiteral` · `StringLiteral`	`init(booleanLiteral:)` · `(stringLiteral:)`
`ArrayLiteral`	`init(arrayLiteral: Element...)`
`DictionaryLiteral`	`init(dictionaryLiteral: (K, V)...)`
`StringInterpolation`	`init(stringInterpolation:)`
`NilLiteral` — **for `Optional` only**	`init(nilLiteral: ())`

Example — operators + subscripts

```
precedencegroup PowerPrecedence {
  higherThan: MultiplicationPrecedence
  associativity: right }
infix operator ** : PowerPrecedence
func ** (b: Double, e: Double) -> Double { pow(b, e) }
struct Vec: Equatable { var x, y: Double
  static func + (l: Vec, r: Vec) -> Vec {
    Vec(x: l.x + r.x, y: l.y + r.y) }
  static func += (l: inout Vec, r: Vec) { l = l + r }
  static prefix func - (v: Vec) -> Vec { Vec(x: -v.x, y: -v.y) } }
struct Grid { var cells: [Int]; let w: Int
  subscript(r: Int, c: Int) -> Int {                // g[1, 2]
    get { cells[r * w + c] }
    set { cells[r * w + c] = newValue } }
  subscript(row r: Int) -> ArraySlice<Int> {        // g[row: 1]
    cells[r * w ..< (r + 1) * w] } }
```

Example — literals, callAsFunction, ~=

```
struct Money: ExpressibleByIntegerLiteral {
  let cents: Int
  init(integerLiteral v: Int) { cents = v * 100 } }
let price: Money = 5                                // 500 cents
struct Scale { let k: Double
  func callAsFunction(_ x: Double) -> Double { x * k } }
let twice = Scale(k: 2); twice(21)                  // 42.0
struct Prefix { let s: String }
func ~= (p: Prefix, v: String) -> Bool { v.hasPrefix(p.s) }
switch path {
case Prefix(s: "/api/"): routeAPI()                 // Prefix ~= path
default: routeWeb() }
if case 200..<300 = status { ok() }                 // Range ~= status
```

Traps

- ! A custom infix operator with no group gets `DefaultPrecedence`: mixing it with + or == unparenthesised does not compile.
- ! Forgetting `associativity: right` on a power operator: the default none rejects `2**3**2`; `left` silently gives 64.
- ! A free == without `: Equatable` is invisible to generics, `Set`, `firstIndex(of:)`; a free < gives no `sort()` — conform to `Comparable`.
- ! `let s: Set = [1, 1, 2]` silently has 2 elements; a dictionary literal with a duplicate key **traps at runtime**.
- ! Overloads + literals multiply the type checker's search: "unable to type-check this expression in reasonable time" — add type annotations, split the expression.
- ! Don't adopt `ExpressibleByNilLiteral` in your types — Apple reserves it for `Optional`.
- ! Operators nobody can read (`<~>`, `|>`) cost more than they save — only for a real algebra (vectors, matrices, parsers).

Remember

"Group parses, function computes; subscripts have no labels; literals wait for a type; `case p` means `p ~= v`."

Related: closures (`@autoclosure`) · key paths (`@dynamicMemberLookup`) · protocols & generics (`Equatable`, `Comparable`) · strings (interpolation) · result builders